

On AI water usage - TL;DW it's very complicated (longer TL;DW in desc)

Posted by u/TheNumberPi_e • • 0 points • 3 comments

Here's my personal TL;DW from watching the video, ofc i recommend you watch the video but I understand most people won't be bothered to interrupt their doomscrolling for a 30 minute video.

- \- Lack of transparency from OpenAI makes calculations hard (and is also hella sus)
- \- Water used in most AI datacenters is fresh water and doesn't get recycled
- \- Each query contains multiple hidden sub-queries, making ressources per query calculations dishonest or disinformated (and approximative)
- \- Training models takes 50% of total AI ressource use, according to the University of California
- \- Water used to make energy (from thermoelectric power plants) isn't accounted for
- \- Thermoelectric power generation takes 45% of total water use worldwide, but it's not using drinkable water. Some "AI water usage numbers" take this into account
- \- GPU creation also needs water, and this water has to be extremely pure water (more energy-hungry than normal water)
- \- Water isn't equally distributed in the world, some water usage might be done in places where water isn't abundant
- \- AI water use is essentially irrelevant when compared to agricultural use (US corn alone uses 80x more water than the worst estimates for AI water use), but it's also non-drinking water
- \- Power usage is a way bigger problem than water use

Comments

u/MysteriousPepper8908 • 5 points • 2025-12-24 15:39 UTC

Note that this tl;dw is pretty much only criticizing Altman's low-ball estimate and not the exaggerated estimates on the other side of the equation which Hank addresses in a much more even-handed way than OP so if you want an actual decent analysis, I recommend just watching the video.

u/Whilpin • 1 points • 2025-12-24 18:33 UTC

Yep, Hank had a very balanced view without throwing numbers at you - just that its hard to actually calculate, thus very easy to make it look either very low power, or insane power

u/MysteriousPepper8908 • 2 points • 2025-12-24 18:55 UTC

And even the high end is dwarfed by other industries, it's just easy to manipulate people who lack an awareness of the actual scale. Water and energy use by AI is quite considerable regardless and only set to increase so it ultimately comes down to the value you place on what it provides.

I see billions of people benefitting from it but someone else will see those same people being harmed by using it and no amount of resource use would be justifiable if the end result is not perceived as beneficial.